

Mike HELLER

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Do you have a favorite teacher that made an impact on your life, and how? (Limit to 100 words)

Different teachers, different eras - but all of them showed confidence in a little kid without a clue: Mr. Brodersen from Washington School, Mrs. Anderson at Jackson Jr. High, Orv Wilkin at Willowbrook.

What was your favorite hang-out place in High School?

Burger King.

What were your top 3 favorite songs in High School? Add the artist, if known.

Black Water, Doobie Brothers
Reelin in the Years, Steely Dan
Cold as Ice, Foreigner

What is your fondest memory of Willowbrook High School?(Limit to 100 words)

Freshmen baseball. We had a great team. Coach Brusveen's first year. I threw batting practice most of the time. If I remember right, we only lost one game where we got behind big early. We came back, should have won except for a bad call. Brusveen went nuts and got thrown out of the game. We nearly went undefeated. Great bunch of guys.

Give us a brief history of your life since graduating: (Limit to 300 words)

Spent four great years at U of I then moved to St. Louis. Played ALOT of 12" softball in my 20s until I got married to a nice little gal from Fulton Missouri in 1988. We manufactured and raised 3 kids (we both have no clue how we did that now). Our oldest son just had our first and only granddaughter, they live in Wicker Park. Our daughter and youngest son live in Dallas. I worked at McDonnell Douglas/Boeing the entire time until retirement in 2022.

Tell us about your career path: (Limit to 100 words)

I was an aero engineer, worked aerodynamics and flight controls for F-15, F/A-18A-D, F/A-18E/F/G (my logic is in all three of those flight control computers). I retired as a Technical Fellow with an expertise in high angle of attack controllability - basically preventing the aircraft from crashing. Got involved in demonstrating the aircraft to both the India Air Force and Navy (11 trips to India, ugh). Dabbled with V-22 tilt rotor and T-7 trainer. Was the chief engineer on a project to put an aero shaped fuel tank on the Super Hornet. Turned out that's really hard to do.